

Cubase, with sophisticated tools for all stages of music production – be it recording, editing or mixing. It supports a variety of input and output interfaces and complex signal flow paths, along with an array of FX plugins and software instruments to achieve that perfect sound.

6. WinFF/Sound Converter

Converting media files between different formats is an inescapable task, whether you're trying to compress media to save space or convert media to, say, an iPod-compatible format. FFmpeg is a feature-packed library that supports converting between nearly every known media format along with a tonne of configuration options. However, it's a command line inter-



Use WinFF to convert your videos to an iPod-friendly format

face (CLI) tool, and typing out the various parameters can be daunting and prone to errors. WinFF is a graphical front-end to FFmpeg that eliminates the complexity and has presets for converting videos into different formats. This is especially handy if your target device is a portable media player. Just select your device from the drop-

down list and WinFF will automatically decide the optimal parameters for conversion. Sound Converter is a similar tool for converting between different audio formats.

II. Productivity

Any operating system needs a rich set of productivity tools if it's to be taken seriously, and Linux is no different. While the best productivity apps on Linux don't hold a candle to Microsoft Office, they're still pretty good for the casual user. Most of us use not more than 20 percent of the feature set of Microsoft Word or Excel, so programs such as LibreOffice and GNU Calc should have you covered. On the off chance that you do need that added functionality, you can run Microsoft Office under WINE (short for "Wine Is Not an Emulator") – a program that lets you install and run Windows programs under Linux.